

Diplomystus

DIP-low-MISS-tus

- **When** 55–34 million years ago (Middle to Late Paleogene)
- **Fossil location** USA, Lebanon, Syria, S. America, Africa
- **Habitat** Lakes
- **Length** 26 in (65 cm)

A relative of herrings and sardines, *Diplomystus* lived in freshwater rivers and lakes. Many of the

best-preserved fossils have been found in the Green River region of Wyoming. These show that *Diplomystus* was a predator—a number of smaller fish have been found preserved in the stomachs. This creature had an upward-facing mouth, suggesting that it hunted fish that swam just below the surface of the water.



Naso

NAY-zoe

- **When** 56–49 million years ago (Paleogene)
- **Fossil location** Italy
- **Habitat** Oceans
- **Length** 3 in (8 cm)

This fossil fish is a very close relative of modern unicorn fish, which are so named because they have a spike on the forehead like a unicorn's horn. Like its modern relatives, this prehistoric species may have lived in shoals on coral reefs.



Knightia

NITE-ee-ah

- **When** 55–34 million years ago (Middle to Late Paleogene)
- **Fossil location** USA
- **Habitat** Rivers and lakes of N. America
- **Length** 10 in (25 cm)

Scientists have discovered skeletons of *Knightia* in the stomachs of many larger fish. Huge shoals must have crowded the ancient seas, making them easy prey. Hundreds of well-preserved *Knightia* fossils have been found in the Green River region of Wyoming. The State of Wyoming declared *Knightia* as its state fossil in 1987.



Priscacara

PRISS-ca-carr-a



- **When** 55–33 million years ago (Middle to Late Paleogene)
- **Fossil location** N. America
- **Habitat** Freshwater streams and lakes
- **Length** 6 in (15 cm)

Priscacara lived in deep lakes in North America, where its fossils formed in mud on the lake floor, preserved in beautiful detail. The stiff spines of its fins may have been defensive weapons—they would probably have stabbed the mouth of any predator that tried to swallow *Priscacara*.

Perca

PER-ca

- **When** 55–37 million years ago (Middle to Late Paleogene)
- **Fossil location** USA
- **Habitat** Shallow waters
- **Length** 12 in (30 cm)

This ancient fish of the perch family looked just like its modern relative. Its body was covered in scales. On its humped back were two fins bearing sharp spines that it raised to scare away predators. Like many perches today, it may have had a striped body that helped it blend in with the reeds and bulrushes among which it hid from predators. It moved in shoals, feeding on insects, fish eggs, and small fish.



Mioplosus

MY-oh-PLOH-sus

- **When** 55–40 million years ago (Middle Paleogene)
- **Fossil location** USA
- **Habitat** Oceans
- **Length** 10 in (25 cm)

This incredible fossil shows a *Mioplosus* caught in the act of devouring its prey. The victim must have become lodged in the predator's mouth, killing it. *Mioplosus* was a hunter that preyed on fish up to half its size, using pointed teeth to trap them in its jaws.

